

Module 02: Agents — The Witness and the Witnessed

Learning Objectives

1. Examine the concept of **agency** as it appears in contemplative experience — the shifting boundary between "I am watching" and "watching is happening."
2. Explain how active inference construes the agent as a **process of self-modeling** rather than a fixed entity, and how this aligns with contemplative insights into the constructed nature of the self.
3. Analyze the role of **minimal selfhood** (Gallagher) and **self-as-process** in the enactive account of living presence.
4. Recognize how present-moment awareness reveals agency as an ongoing inferential construction rather than a pre-given fact.

Introduction

In meditation, a curious reversal sometimes occurs. You begin by watching your breath — "I am the one who watches." But as attention deepens, the sense of a separate watcher begins to dissolve. There is breathing. There is awareness of breathing. But the "I" who watches has become strangely transparent, as though the boundary between observer and observed has thinned to the point of disappearance. Who is the agent here? Is it the "I" that initiated the practice, or is it the living system whose ongoing self-organization includes both the breathing and the awareness of breathing?

This question is not merely philosophical. It strikes at the heart of how active inference conceives of agency. In the free energy framework, an agent is not a homunculus sitting behind the eyes. It is the entire self-organizing process by which a living system maintains its Markov blanket — predicting, acting, and updating in a continuous loop. The felt sense of being an agent — the "I" that seems to watch, decide, and act — is itself a prediction of the generative model, a high-level inference about the system's own causal role. Living presence

reveals this inference at work, sometimes confirming the sense of agency, sometimes gently dissolving it.

Key Concepts

1. The Self as Generative Model Prediction

In active inference, there is no need for a central self that orchestrates the organism's activity. The "self" is better understood as the generative model's prediction about its own persistence and coherence — a deep prior that organizes experience around a center of agency. Anil Seth calls this the "beast machine" perspective: the self is a controlled hallucination, a prediction that the brain generates to maintain the organism's integrity. Contemplative practice reveals this constructedness directly: as mindful attention deepens, the felt self becomes less solid, more process-like, more transparently a product of the model's own activity.

2. Minimal Selfhood and Pre-Reflective Agency

Shaun Gallagher distinguishes between the **minimal self** — the pre-reflective, embodied sense of being a subject of experience — and the **narrative self** — the autobiographical story we tell about who we are. In living presence, the narrative self quiets. The stories about past and future recede. What remains is the minimal self: a bare sense of experiential perspective, a "here-ness" that is not a thought but a felt orientation. In active inference, the minimal self corresponds to the proprioceptive and interoceptive self-model — the generative model's most basic prediction that "there is a body here, and it is mine."

3. The Agent-Observer Duality in Meditation

Many contemplative traditions work explicitly with the relationship between the observer and the observed. Zen Buddhism's koan "Who is the one who hears?" and Ramana Maharshi's self-inquiry "Who am I?" both probe the status of the observing agent. Active inference illuminates this inquiry: the "observer" is not a separate entity but a higher-order prediction generated by the same model that generates the "observed." When the meditator turns attention back on itself — watching the watcher — the model encounters its own self-referential structure, sometimes producing a vertigo of recursion, sometimes producing a liberating recognition that observer and observed are aspects of a single inferential process.

4. Effortless Agency and Wu Wei

The Taoist concept of **wu wei** — effortless action, doing without doing — describes a state in which action arises naturally and spontaneously, without the felt sense of a separate agent forcing it. In active inference, wu wei corresponds to a state in which the generative model's predictions are so well-calibrated to the current situation that motor policies unfold without deliberative interruption. Free energy is minimized at such low levels that there is no prediction error to generate the felt sense of effort. The agent has not disappeared; rather, the model's self-prediction has become so seamless that agency is experienced as a natural flow rather than a separate act of will.

5. The Dissolution and Reconstruction of Agency

Intensive meditation practice occasionally produces experiences of **ego dissolution** — a temporary loss of the sense of being a separate self. In active inference terms, these experiences correspond to a radical reduction in the precision of the self-model: the generative model's prediction of a bounded, persisting agent temporarily loses its grip, and experience continues without an experiential center. These states, while often profound, are transient. The self-model reconstructs as practice continues, but the meditator returns with a loosened attachment to the fixity of selfhood — an experiential understanding that agency is a process, not a thing.

Active Inference Connection

Active inference offers a naturalistic account of what contemplatives discover through practice: the agent is not a ghost in the machine but the machine's own self-model — a prediction generated by the generative model to organize its own activity. Living presence reveals this self-model in real time: sometimes solid and directive, sometimes transparent and process-like, sometimes momentarily absent. The capacity to observe these fluctuations without panic or fixation is the mark of mature contemplative practice — and the formal expression, in active inference terms, of a generative model that has learned to hold its own self-predictions with appropriate precision: confident enough to act, flexible enough to update.

Experiential Applications

- **Practice — Noticing the Arising of "I":** During meditation, watch for the moment when the sense of "I" arises. It may come with a thought ("I should focus harder"), a judgment ("I am doing this wrong"), or a desire ("I want this to continue"). Notice that before the "I" appeared, experience was happening without a felt agent. The sense of agency is an event, not a constant — a prediction that the generative model generates and withdraws. Can you catch the moment of its construction?
- **Case Study — Depersonalization and the Loss of Felt Agency:** Depersonalization disorder involves a chronic loss of the felt sense of being a real, embodied agent — the world seems dreamlike, one's own actions seem mechanical, the self feels unreal. In active inference terms, depersonalization reflects pathologically low precision on the self-model: the generative model fails to generate the confident prediction of "I am here, I am real, I am acting" that normally constitutes felt agency. Treatment involves gently rebuilding the precision of the self-model through grounding practices — feeling the body, making contact with physical objects, engaging in deliberate, mindful action that generates confirmatory feedback.

Cross-References

- **Module 01 (Systems):** The systemic self-organization on which agency is built — the agent emerges from the system.
- **Module 03 (Perception):** How the present-moment agent perceives — the relationship between who is looking and what is seen.
- **Unit 01 (Felt Sense):** The interoceptive dimension of agency — feeling oneself as the author of experience.

Summary

Agency, seen through the lens of living presence, is not a fixed essence but an ongoing inferential construction — the generative model's prediction of its own causal role in the world. Contemplative practice reveals this construction in real time: the sense of "I" arises and dissolves, solidifies and becomes transparent, sometimes vanishes entirely before

reassembling. Active inference naturalizes these contemplative discoveries, showing that the self is a controlled inference rather than a metaphysical given. The mature practitioner holds this insight lightly — inhabiting agency fully while recognizing its constructed, process-like nature.